historians suggest. It isn't that he could not read or write: according to Annemarie Schimmel, there even exists 'one small note written by [Akbar] in clear Arabic letters'. Besides, at the time, Akbar's inability to read or write 'testifie[d] to Akbar's greatness, not to any deficiency'. He wasn't illiterate, he was '*ummi*', just as the Prophet Muhammad was ummi, a term that, 'in the tradition of Islamic mysticism, has come to mean an inspired mystic'[13] – and fit very neatly, therefore, with Akbar's, and his friends' and flatterers', idea of the emperor as a messiah.

Unlettered, dyslexic or divine, Akbar's appetite for literature was as boundless as his curiosity about faith.[14] Many of the books that were read out to him were commissioned by the emperor himself, often from his busy translation department working on Hindi, Greek, Arabic and Persian literature. And if Akbar could not read, he could certainly absorb; it was his most disgruntled translator Badauni who wrote, with no intention to flatter, that the emperor 'by a peculiar acquisitiveness and a talent for selection, by no means common, had made his own all that can be seen and read in books'.[15]

These days, however, the emperor's evenings had become less convivial. In fact, Asad Beg writes that Akbar had begun to 'retire for a long interval' after his evening prayers.[16] Perhaps he tired more easily as he aged, and needed a nap. Or perhaps he did not find peace in other people's stories any more; wanting, instead, to be alone and piece together the memory of his children when they were yet unshattered by their foibles. His servants and courtiers had grown accustomed to Akbar's absence at this time of day, and would 'disperse' in the evenings, only returning when they 'expected His Majesty to re-appear'.

One particular evening, however, sometime in the summer of 1604, Akbar was unusually keen to hold court. It was Asad Beg, in fact, who caused this spurt of enthusiasm. He had just returned from a diplomatic mission to Bijapur and escorted a Bijapuri princess to Daniyal, who was to marry her as part of a largely unsuccessful Mughal attempt to build marital alliances in the Deccan.

Akbar, eager to hear all the news, arrived in court and found it deserted. To add insult to injury, a 'luckless lamplighter [was] coiled up like a snake', fast asleep, near the throne. In a fury, Akbar had the man thrown off a